

8.2 The Mission Area

Zone Threat Levels

First and foremost, every section of the Exclusion Zone has been categorized by Threat Level (TL). The TL is a standing assessment of that area's danger based on reconnaissance, scientific monitoring, and incident reports. It also reflects the type and quantity of potential Salvage, hostile creatures, and presence of anomalies.

The Threat Levels are color-coded on all official Zone maps: Blue, Yellow, or Red, designated TL1, TL2, or TL3 respectively.

Blue 1 Low Threat Levels are on the perimeter, Yellow 2 Medium TLs are a bit farther in, and Red 3 High Threat Level areas are found in the deepest parts of the Zone near the center. As a rule, the higher the Threat Level, the greater chance of locating valuable Salvage – and of encountering dangerous hostile forces and hazardous environments.

Crew Leaders always choose which areas they explore, what jobs they take, what risks and rewards they are willing to face. A low TL equals low risk, but minimal

Salvage. If you want big money, it means you have to play big stakes. Just remember the Zone plays for keeps. Every mission will be walking the razor's edge between staying alive and making a living.

Mission Objectives, Turn Limits, and Hot Spots

In order to keep *Zona Alfa* games focused and moving, there are three key ingredients to every scenario: a single, important Mission Objective, Turn Limits, and evenly distributed Hot Spots. The Mission Objective keeps players focused on a goal, a Turn Limit ensures everyone is on the move instead of camping and sniping, and the Hot Spots provide secondary opportunities for loot and Campaign Advances.

A **Mission Objective** is the main reason for the scenario. It can be something as simple as recovering an item from an abandoned building, or escorting a scientist to a specific spot on the table. It can be complex, or multi-stage, like clearing out a nest of mutants before repairing a cell tower to restore communication in the region. Whatever you decide, achieving the Mission Objective gets the successful team the lion's share of that game's Campaign Advances and allows them one free roll on the appropriate TL Salvage Table.

Turn Limits in *Zona Alfa* raise the tension and force players to make tough choices. For smaller, 3' x 3' or 4' x 4' sized game areas, the Turn Limit is 4 +D3 turns. For larger tables with more players, bump the Turn Limit up to 6 +D3 turns. Here's your excuse to buy (or make) that cool turn counter you wanted. The reason for the deadline can be anything from an imminent Emission, to a Zone Enforcement recon fly-over, or a stampeding herd of mutants. Whatever it is, the teams have a definite window to operate in the mission area and accomplish the objective.

Hot Spots are different from Mission Objectives. Hot Spots are specific locations on the battlefield, say a tool shed, a stand of trees, or even a stack of crates on the south side, third floor by the corner window in an abandoned warehouse. They can also be a scenic item like an abandoned vehicle, a crashed UAV, or a dead body. This indicates not only the presence of valuable Salvage but also the probability of danger. All Hot Spots should be clearly marked with a token or chit.

The number of Hot Spots on the battlefield is determined by the Threat Level of the area being explored. The number of Hot Spots in a given mission area is the Threat Level (TL) multiplied by 2. So, a Threat Level 1 area would have 2 Hot Spots. A Threat Level 2 area would have 4, and a Threat Level 3 area would have 6. Distribute them evenly throughout the board, giving both sides equal accessibility. Hot Spots are secondary, optional mission goals in the game, additional to the main Mission Objective.

Triggering Mission Objectives and Hot Spots

If all anyone had to do was walk up and flip a switch or grab the black box to get rich, the Zone would be overrun with slackers, hoodlums, and posers. But nothing is that easy. There's always a catch.

Mission Objectives and Hot Spots are where the 'Risk v Reward' dilemma kicks in. Both grant valuable experience and Salvage, but engaging with them always triggers a response from **Zone Hostiles** – the strange, dangerous creatures who make their home in the Exclusion Zone.

Anytime a player's models pass through or end their movement within 3" of the Mission Objective or Hot Spot, the player has triggered the location. This 3" distance, or 6" diameter centered on the item, is known as the location's Reaction Radius. When triggered, the player responsible must roll on the Zone Hostiles Table (see page 41) to determine the Zone's response to the intrusion. This means, in essence, Mission Objectives and Hot Spots are area effect locations. Use a ruler or make a 6" template

to determine the location's precise reaction radius. Center it on the scenic item – any model touching or within the template's reach triggers the Hot Spot.

Bolt Toss

Mission Objectives and Hot Spots can also be triggered by other means. Players can have one of their models Toss a Bolt into the location's 3" Reaction Radius to make the Zone Hostiles spawn. Simply have a crew member declare the intention and spend the Action to make the attempt (treat as a grenade throw, see pages 12 and 27). If successful, this Bolt Toss triggers the location and the Zone Hostiles spawn according to the rules. If unsuccessful, the Action is spent and nothing happens.

Bolt Toss allows players to trigger the location remotely, either with a nearby comrade on Alert, or when a rival crew is in proximity (Zone Hostiles attack the nearest model in clear Line of Sight, see pages 5 and 15 for further details).

Binoculars and the Inspect Action also come in handy here as they make it possible for a crew to check out the area from a distance and tweak which type of Zone Hostile spawns – for better or worse.

Clearing Mission Objectives and Hot Spots

Remember both Mission Objectives and Hot Spots trigger Zone Hostiles. In order to accomplish a Mission Objective or clear and search a Hot Spot, the Zone Hostiles associated with that location must first be eliminated.

Once that is done, at least one crew member must spend one Action to interact or search the location. Some Objective or Hot Spots may require additional Actions or even a Skill Check to clear, as dictated by that particular Zone Run.

8.3 Zone Hostiles

Whenever a Mission Objective or Hot Spot is engaged, the player responsible for triggering the Zone Hostiles rolls a D6 and checks the table below in the appropriate Threat Level column. The Zone Hostile miniatures appear immediately. The number in parentheses indicates the number of figures that spawn.

Zone Hostiles by Threat Level

Zone Hostiles Table			
D6 Roll	Threat Level 1 Blue	Threat Level 2 Yellow	Threat Level 3 Red
1	Vermin Swarm (1)	Vermin Swarm (X 2)	Feral Dogs (6)
2	Vermin Swarm (2)	Feral Dogs (6)	Zombies (8)
3	Feral Dogs (4)	Zombies (6)	Rad Ghouls (6)
4	Zombies (4)	Rad Ghouls (6)	Bandits (4) *
5	Rad Ghoul (4)	Bandits (4) *	Mutants (2) *
6	Bandits (4) *	Mutant (1) *	Large Mutant (1) *

* indicates the presence of an Anomaly. Roll on the Artifact Table **after** all standard Hostiles and Salvage issues are resolved (see page 46).

Quick Note on Zone Hostiles

As Zona Alfa isn't tied to any particular line of miniatures and the goal is to allow players to use figures in their collection, the Zone Hostiles are of a generic, post-apocalyptic type. Substitute as needed. If you don't have feral dogs for instance, use spiders. If you want to use rat men instead of ghouls, or already have a nice selection of hooded cultists, go for it. Simply scale their abilities to fit the threat they represent. Take a look at the Zone Hostile Stat Table (see page 44) and tweak as needed. So long as it works for you and your gaming group, roll with it and keep playing.

Zone Hostiles Deployment

Zone Hostile miniatures are placed on the table using the D10 Indirect Fire Deviation method (see page 27), with the deviation calculated from the center of the Hot Spot. Hostile models appear instantly and can make one free move to seek cover or engage the nearest visible enemy.

Once Zone Hostiles appear, they join the Initiative/Activation sequence in **last place**. If multiple Hot Spots have been triggered and a number of Zone Hostiles are present, one unit from each separate Zone Hostile force activates after the other, until one unit from each group has gone. Then the new round of Activation begins. (Yes, this can lead to a wave of Zone Hostiles moving in on the crews. The Alert Action will come in useful here).

Alternate Deployment for Zone Hostiles

There may be times when it is more logical in the scenario to have the Zone Hostiles already deployed and visible on the table at the start of the game. Say your crews are entering an area known to be infested with mutants or controlled by Bandits. In that case, simply place them to the best advantage around the particular Hot Spot or Objective and start the game. That Hot Spot or Objective is considered Triggered. No further rolls are necessary. Visible Hostiles follow the same A.I. Rules as those that are triggered.

Zone Hostile A.I. Rules and Control

Zone Hostile models – either those triggered by a Hot Spot/Mission Objective, or present on the battlefield at the start of scenario – follow **four** basic rules:

1. They are centered around that specific location on the table and will not range further than 12" from it.
2. They are aggressive and will always attack within that territory, using Cover whenever possible.
3. They always attack the closest, visible model. Enemies in the open take priority over those in cover. If multiple opponents are present, they will attack the one in clearest Line of Sight, continuing to attack that opponent until either it or they are destroyed.
4. They will defend themselves if attacked in Melee. Only Melee attacks can draw their attention away from the closest, visible opponent.

All Zone Hostile models are controlled (moved and rolled) by the opposing player. So if your team triggered a Hot Spot and is attacked by Hostiles, the **other player** moves and rolls all Attack, Defense, and Will dice. Zone Hostile control will shift between players, depending on whose crew the Hostiles are attacking.

The number of Actions a Zone Hostile can take is linked to the Threat Level area. With one Action for TL1, two Actions for TL2, and three Actions for TL3.

Hostile models DO NOT trigger other Hot Spots, only player models.

Zone Hostile Stat Table					
Zone Hostile	Move	Combat Ability	Armor	Will	Weapon
Vermin	6"	4	2	4	Teeth/Claws
Dogs	8"	4	2	4	Teeth/Claws
Zombies	4"	4	6	NA	Teeth/Claws
Ghoul	7"	5	4	6	Big Teeth/Claws
Bandit	6"	5	5	6	Ranged/Melee per Armory
Mutant	6"	Range: 4-6	4-6	6	Big Teeth/Claws
Large Mutant	6"	Range: 5-7	5-7	7	Very Big Teeth/Claws

Zone Hostile Weapons

The Zone Hostile Stat Table is a guide. Tweak as necessary to suit the scenario and your particular miniature collection. See the Armory in Section 5 and outfit as needed (see page 24). Feel free to increase Firepower on Melee attackers, say from a 1 for a zombie's slow, clumsy assault to a 2 or 3 to reflect a ghoul or rabid dog's frenzied mauling. Bandits can use any Ranged or Melee weapon in the Armory. Increase Combat Experience Stats and Equipment if your scenario calls for something like a rogue military unit or a rival NPC Crew.

Quick Note on Zone Hostile Experience Levels

If the standard rule of linking Zone Hostile Experience levels/Actions per turn to the Threat level of the mission area is too easy, then by all means bump the Stats. This is your game. Rabid dogs, rager zombies, a seasoned bandit crew, or military patrol all obviously present more of threat, regardless of what TL Area they were encountered in. However, if your crews are consistently outgunned by Zone Hostiles, consider scaling them back a bit.

8.4 Salvage, Anomalies, Environmental Hazards

Salvage

Rubles, that's what this is all about, right? Otherwise, we'd get a job.

After, and only after, the Hostiles guarding a particular Mission Objective or Hot Spot are eliminated can the area be Searched for valuable Salvage and the Mission Objectives. Hot Spots yield Salvage and each Hot Spot can only be Searched **once**. An exception to this is if a model has the Salvager ability (see page 30). They can spend two Actions to Search and find Salvage twice. Roll on the table below and determine the Salvage value/item according to Threat Level. Once Salvage has been retrieved, remove the Hot Spot token. The area is no longer viable for searching.

Salvage Table by Level			
D6 Roll	Threat Level 1 Blue	Threat Level 2 Yellow	Threat Level 3 Red
1	Salvage Value 200	Salvage Value 350	Salvage Value 500
2	Salvage Value 350	Salvage Value 500	Salvage Value 750
3	Salvage Value 500	Salvage Value 750	Salvage Value 1,000
4	Salvage Value 200 plus one roll on Basic Equipment Table	Salvage Value 500 plus two rolls on Basic Equipment Table	Salvage Value 750 plus two rolls on Advanced Equipment Table*
5	Salvage Value 350 plus one roll on Basic Equipment Table	Salvage Value 750 plus two rolls on Basic Equipment Table *	Salvage Value 1,000 plus two rolls on Advanced Equipment Table*
6	Salvage Value 500 plus one roll on Basic Equipment Table *	Salvage Value 1,000 plus one roll on Advanced Equipment Table*	Salvage Value 2,000 plus one roll each on the Advanced Equipment Table and the Special Items Table*
* indicates the presence of an Anomaly. Roll on the Artifact Table after all standard Hostiles and Salvage issues are resolved. See page 46 for more information.			

Every crew member is equipped with a backpack for holding valuable Salvage and recovered Equipment. There's no real limit to the amount of Salvage a model can carry. Carrying such items does not use Equipment Slots; they are tucked away and inaccessible for the duration of the mission. However, they can be distributed among various team members and used in later games.

Anomalies

Anomalies are what set the Exclusion Zone apart from every other devastated, quarantined area in the history of the planet. Anomalies are micro-distortions in the flow of space and time that seem to bend the laws of physics. While certainly unique, mysterious, and potentially hazardous, they also yield strange and valuable Artifacts. The potential for Anomalous Hot Spots is contingent on the area's Threat Level and the chance of encountering Anomalies increases by Threat Level.

In a TL 1 Area, any time a 6 is rolled when triggering a Mission Objective or Hot Spot, the location not only contains Salvage but also an Anomaly. In TL 2 areas, an Anomaly is present on a roll of 5+, in TL 3 sectors, a 4+. When the appropriate die result is rolled, the player also rolls on the Artifact Table. This roll/effect is in **addition** to the regular Threat and Salvage table rolls, and represents the presence of additional dangerous, uncommon phenomenon and rare, valuable Salvage.

Anomalies generate no additional Zone Hostiles (they are dangerous enough on their own!). The standard Zone Hostiles and Salvage issues are always resolved first.

Searching Anomalies for Artifacts

Anomalies are treated as an Area Effect similar to a grenade blast. In order to avoid the effects of the Anomaly and retrieve whatever Artifact lies at its center, the Model must expend one Action to Search, as well as pass a Will check. The Will check is taken prior to the Search Action and does not cost an Action. The Target Number for this Will check is the searching model's Will stat, with a negative modifier equivalent to the mission area's Threat Level.

Nearby Leaders grant a bonus to this roll, as does having the Detector Equipment equipped in one of their Slots. However, the model performing the Search must have it listed as a piece of Gear.

Anomaly Effect

If the Will check is unsuccessful, the Anomaly is triggered and all models within or touched by the Hot Spot radius (Large Blast Template) take a Damage 2 attack.

If the Search Action is successful, the searcher has skillfully navigated their way through the Anomaly and may roll a D6 on the Artifact Table below.

Note that models with the Salvager ability may Search an Anomaly twice but must pay the Action cost and pass the Will check each time. Only the Salvager can pull Two Artifacts from an Anomaly. Once an Artifact has been removed from the Anomaly, the area goes inert and is no longer viable.

Artifacts

A warped length of steel rod. A pinecone crackling with greenish electricity. A soap bubble that glows like a light bulb and won't burst. A flap of cloth that undulates as if alive... these and many other strange objects have recovered in the Exclusion Zone. Forged by the immense and bizarre distortion of natural forces inside an Anomaly, they are highly sought after by scientists, governments, corporations, and private collectors not merely for their other-worldly uniqueness, but for the rare, almost magical properties they possess.

Below is a table of Artifacts commonly found in a majority of the Anomalies encountered to date. This list is by no means exhaustive, as the landscape in the Zone is constantly shifting in subtle but profound ways. Who knows what new items will be found and who can say what properties they might possess?

After a Successful Search in an Anomaly, roll a D6 and determine which Artifact has been retrieved.

Artifact Table	
D6 Roll	Artifact
1	Artifact Value 2,000
2	Artifact Value 3,500
3	Artifact Value 4,500
4	Artifact Value 4,500 + Movement bonus (+1")
5	Artifact Value 5,000 + Armor bonus (+1 Armor)
6	Artifact Value 5,500 + Will bonus (+1 Will)

Environmental Hazards (Optional)

To say the Exclusion Zone is having something of a climate crisis is an understatement. In addition to being home to bandits, beasts, mutants, physical and anomalies, the Zone is known for strange and severe weather conditions. At the start of each Zone Run, roll a single D6 against the Environmental Hazard Table and apply the results. Feel free to ignore this section or restrict it to higher Threat Level Areas.

Environmental Hazard Table	
D6 Roll	Environmental Hazard
1	Overcast: No Effect
2	Sudden Darkness: LOS/LOF ranges are cut to 12"
3	Overcast: No Effect
4	Rainstorm: All Movement at -1". Ranged Attacks at half range
5	Sunny Day: No Effect
6	High Radiation Area: Subtract 1 from the Turn Limit. All Salvage Rolls are x2